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Cyber Security Career Guide 2026

45-Day Structured Learning Breakdown

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The Reality Check (Why Most Fail)

The Reality Check (Why Most Fail)

Most people fail because they do this:

❌ "I'll start hacking" → without networking + OS
❌ Watch tutorials → no labs, no proof
❌ Learn tools → but can't explain "why it works"
❌ Apply for jobs → with zero portfolio

Cybersecurity interviews test:

1. How you think
2. How you investigate
3. How you document
4. How you stay legal + structured

This guide fixes the order.

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Choose Your Track (2026 Roles Map)

Cybersecurity is not one job.

Track A: SOC / Blue Team (Most hiring)

- Logs, alerts, detection, incident response
- Tools: SIEM, EDR, threat intel

Track B: Pentest / Red Team (High skill ceiling)

- Web app testing, exploitation basics, reporting
- Tools: Burp, Nmap, Linux, scripts

Track C: GRC / Risk (Non-coding friendly)

- Policy, compliance, audits, risk assessment
- Great for business + security minded people

This 45-day plan gives **core foundation + fork paths**.

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Days 1–2: Cybersecurity Fundamentals (The Big Picture)
Learn

- CIA Triad: Confidentiality, Integrity, Availability
- Threat vs Vulnerability vs Risk
- Attack Surface (where attackers enter)
- Basic security controls: preventive / detective / corrective
- Security domains: network, endpoint, identity, cloud, app

Do

- Pick any real company (Netflix / Zomato / Paytm)
- Write: “If I had to protect this company, what are top 10 risks?”

Output

- 1-page “Security Thinking” note (your first portfolio artifact)

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Day 3: Networking Basics (Non-Negotiable)
If you don't understand networking, you won't understand **how attacks actually work**.
Every cyber attack is ultimately **data moving across a network**.

Core Concepts You Must Understand

IP Address
An IP address is the **logical identity** of a device on a network. Security teams track suspicious activity by IPs — failed logins, unusual locations, repeated requests.

MAC Address
A MAC address is the **physical identity** of a device's network card. It helps identify **specific machines** inside local networks and detect unauthorized devices.

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

DNS (Domain Name System)
DNS translates human-friendly names into IP addresses. Many attacks start here — phishing domains, malicious redirects, DNS-based command-and-control traffic.

DHCP
DHCP automatically assigns IP addresses to devices. Misconfigured DHCP can expose networks to **rogue devices** and internal attacks.

Ports & Protocols
Ports are entry points to services (e.g., 80, 443, 22).
TCP ensures reliable delivery (used in logins, file transfers).
UDP is fast but connectionless (used in streaming, DNS).
Security monitoring often flags **unusual ports or protocols**.

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Network Components

- **Router**: connects networks
- **Switch**: connects devices inside a network
- **Firewall**: allows or blocks traffic based on rules
- **NAT**: hides internal IPs from the public internet

These define **where attackers can and cannot go**.

What Is a Packet?

A packet is a **small unit of data** sent over the network.
Firewalls, IDS, and SIEM tools analyze packets to detect malicious behavior.

Hands-On Task (Must Do)

Draw your **home Wi-Fi network**:
Router → Laptop → Mobile → Internet

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Output:

Upload a screenshot/photo + write **8–10 lines explaining**:

- How data flows
- Where security controls exist
- What could be attacked

(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Day 4: Linux Basics (Security Runs on Linux)

Most servers, cloud workloads, security tools, and attack infrastructure run on **Linux**.

If you can't navigate Linux, you can't investigate incidents properly.

What You Learn

Linux File System

- /etc → system & security configurations
- /var → logs (very important for investigations)
- /home → user data and permissions

Users & Permissions

- Linux security is permission-driven
- rwx controls **who can read, write, or execute**
- sudo = controlled privilege escalation (often abused by attackers)

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Core Commands

- ls, cd, cat → navigation & reading
- grep, tail → log analysis
- chmod → permission changes
- ps, netstat/ss → running processes & network connections

Why Logs Matter

Logs tell you what happened, when, and by whom — the backbone of incident response.

Hands-On Task

Create a user → create files → change permissions → view logs.

Output

Linux commands cheat sheet (10 commands + real use cases)

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Days 5–6: Windows + Identity Basics

Most enterprise attacks start or end on **Windows machines**.
Identity misuse is one of the **top breach causes**.
What You Learn

Users & Groups

- Normal users vs admin users
- Why admin access is dangerous if misused

Windows Event Logs

- Authentication events
- Privilege escalation attempts
- System & security activity

Active Directory (Concept)

- Central identity system for enterprises
- One compromise can affect **hundreds of machines**

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Authentication vs Authorization

- Authentication = *Who are you?*
- Authorization = What are you allowed to do?

Security Controls

- Password policies
- Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)
- Least privilege principle

Hands-On Task

Explore Windows security settings + Event Viewer.

Output

1-page note: **"Windows security concepts I understand now"**

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Day 7: Security Mindset + Ethics (VERY IMPORTANT)

Cybersecurity without ethics is **illegal hacking**.

What You Learn

Legal Boundaries

- Test only what you own or have permission for
- Unauthorized testing = crime (even if intention is learning)

Vulnerability Disclosure

- How researchers report issues responsibly
- Why proof + documentation matter

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(Days 1–7): Foundations That Make You Dangerous (Legally)

Why Documentation Protects You

- Shows intent
- Shows professionalism
- Builds trust with employers

Hands-On Task

Write **your personal Ethical Security Rules** (5 bullets).

Output

Add it to your **portfolio README**.

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(Days 8–15) Web + Threat Basics

Slide 10 — Days 8–9: Web Fundamentals (To Understand Web Attacks)

Most attacks today target **web applications**.

What You Learn

Request–Response Cycle

- Browser sends request → server responds
- Attacks manipulate this flow

Sessions & Tokens

- How users stay logged in
- Why token theft = account takeover

Browser Storage

- Cookies, local storage, session storage
- Misuse leads to data exposure

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(Days 8–15) Web + Threat Basics

HTTP Methods & Status Codes

- Methods define actions
- Status codes reveal security behavior

Hands-On Task

Inspect real network calls using browser DevTools.

Output

"How the web works" notes + **1 real example**

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(Days 8–15) Web + Threat Basics

Days 10–12: OWASP Top Risks (2026 Relevant)

These are **real interview topics**, not theory.

What You Learn

- Broken Access Control
- Injection concepts
- Authentication failures
- Security misconfiguration
- Sensitive data exposure
- SSRF (cloud-era critical risk)

Hands-On Task

For each risk, write:

- What it means
- How it happens
- How teams prevent it

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(Days 8–15) Web + Threat Basics

Days 13–15: Malware + Threat Landscape
Understanding threats makes detection easier.
What You Learn
Malware Types

- Trojan, worm, ransomware, spyware

Phishing Variants

- Spear phishing
- Smishing
- Vishing

Attack Chain
Recon → Initial Access → Persistence → Exfiltration
Hands-On Task
Analyze 3 phishing examples (subject + tactic + red flags).
Output
Phishing detection checklist (viral content)

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(Days 8–15) Web + Threat Basics

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Phishing detection checklist (viral content)

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(Days 16–25) SOC Foundations

Days 16–17: Logs (Language of Blue Team)
Logs are **evidence**, not noise.

What You Learn

- Authentication logs
- Process activity
- Network events
- File changes
- Importance of timestamps & usernames

Hands-On Task
Create table: event → what to check → why it matters.

Output
SOC-style **investigation quick table**

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(Days 16–25) SOC Foundations

Days 18–20: SIEM Basics
This is how alerts are created.

What You Learn

- Log collection & correlation
- False positives vs real threats
- Alert severity & triage logic

Hands-On Task
Write 5 realistic detection ideas.

Output
“My first 5 detections” write-up

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(Days 16–25) SOC Foundations

Days 21–22: Endpoint + EDR Basics
Endpoints are prime targets.

What You Learn

- What endpoints are
- Why EDR matters
- Process trees & suspicious behavior

Hands-On Task
Practice **process tree thinking**.

Output
Simple diagram + explanation

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(Days 16–25) SOC Foundations

Days 23–25: Incident Response (IR)
IR is **decision-making under pressure**.

What You Learn

- IR lifecycle
- Containment vs eradication
- Evidence handling basics

Hands-On Task
Create IR playbook for phishing + malware scenario.

Output
1-page **IR playbook**

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(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

Days 26–27: Recon + Scanning

What You Learn

- Recon vs scanning vs enumeration
- Ports = exposed services
- Exposure increases risk

Hands-On Task

Interpret legal lab scan results.

Output

“How I interpret scan results” notes

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(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

Days 28–30: Vulnerability Thinking

Tools don't make you skilled — **thinking does**.

What You Learn

- CVE & CVSS concepts
- Context matters more than score

Hands-On Task

Analyze 3 famous vulnerabilities.

Output

Vulnerability case-study notes

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(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

Days 31–33: Web Testing Foundations

What You Learn

- Input validation
- Session weaknesses
- Access control logic

Hands-On Task

Create a web security test checklist.

Output

Web testing checklist (save-worthy)

(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

Days 34–35: Secure Configuration & Hardening

What This Slide Is Really About

Most real-world breaches **do not happen because of zero-day hacks**.

They happen because systems are:

- Left on **default settings**
- Not patched
- Poorly configured

Hardening is about **reducing attack surface** before an attacker even tries.

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(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

What You Learn

Default Configurations Are Dangerous

- Default usernames, open ports, unnecessary services
- Attackers assume defaults first — because many teams never change them

Patch Management

- Vulnerabilities are often already known
- Delayed patching = known doors left unlocked
- Security teams track *what is patched vs what is exposed*

Secure Baselines

- A baseline = minimum secure configuration for a system
- Ensures consistency across devices
- Makes detection easier (anything outside baseline = suspicious)

(Days 26–35) Pentest + Defense

Hands-On Task

Create **Top 10 Laptop Hardening Rules**, for example:

- Disable unused services
- Enable firewall
- Strong passwords + auto-lock
- OS & software auto-updates
- Least privilege user accounts

Output

A **Hardening Checklist**

This shows recruiters you understand **preventive security**, not just response.

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Cloud + Career (Days 36–45)

Days 36–38: Cloud Security Basics (2026 Must-Have)

Why This Matters

Most companies now run on cloud platforms.
Most cloud breaches happen due to **misconfiguration**, not hacking.

What You Learn

Shared Responsibility Model

- Cloud provider secures infrastructure
- Customer secures data, identities, configurations
- Many breaches happen because teams misunderstand this split

Identity & Access Management (IAM)

- Who can access what
- Over-permissive roles = major risk
- Identity misuse is more common than malware in cloud attacks

Cloud + Career (Days 36–45)

Storage Misconfiguration Risks

- Public buckets
- Exposed backups
- Sensitive files accessible without authentication

Hands-On Task
Write **Top 10 Cloud Security Mistakes Companies Make**
(Example: public storage, weak IAM roles, no logging)

Output
A **Cloud Security Checklist**
This immediately signals **2026 relevance** to employers.

Cloud + Career (Days 36–45)

Days 39–40: Threat Intelligence (Think Like an Attacker)

Why Threat Intel Matters
Attackers **reuse techniques**.
Security teams win by recognizing **patterns early**.

What You Learn
IOC (Indicators of Compromise)

- IP addresses
- Domains
- File hashes
- These help identify *known malicious activity*.

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Cloud + Career (Days 36–45)

TTP (Tactics, Techniques, Procedures)

- How attackers think and operate
- Initial access methods
- Persistence techniques

Pattern Reuse

- Same malware families
- Same phishing styles
- Same infrastructure reuse

Hands-On Task

Analyze a **real ransomware case**:

- How attackers entered
- What systems they targeted

Cloud + Career (Days 36–45)

- How defenders could detect it earlier

Output
A **1-page Threat Report**
This is **SOC-level portfolio content**, not beginner fluff.

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Days 41–43: Portfolio Projects (NON-NEGOTIABLE)

Why This Slide Is Critical

Recruiters don't hire based on:
❌ courses
❌ certificates
❌ buzzwords

They hire based on **proof of thinking and execution**.

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Days 41–43: Portfolio Projects (NON-NEGOTIABLE)

Project 1 — Incident Report Pack (Blue Team)

Scenario:

- Suspicious login
- Malware download

Deliverables:

- Timeline of events
- Affected systems
- Containment steps
- IOC list
- Final recommendations

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Days 41–43: Portfolio Projects (NON-NEGOTIABLE)

Project 2 — Security Assessment Report

Scenario:

- Demo app or legal lab

Deliverables:

- Findings
- Severity & impact
- Clear remediation steps (most important)

Output
2 PDFs + GitHub/Notion page
This becomes your **primary interview talking point**.

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Days 44: Resume + LinkedIn

Day 44: Resume + LinkedIn (Cybersecurity Version)

Key Message in cybersecurity:
Proof > Buzzwords

What You Must Show

- What you *built*, *analyzed*, or *documented*
- Real skills: IR playbook, detections, reports
- Tools only if you actually used them

Hands-On Task

Rewrite headline like:
Aspiring SOC Analyst | Incident Response & Detection Projects | 45-Day Cyber Portfolio

Output

Updated LinkedIn + **featured portfolio link**

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Days 45: Interviews + Applications

Day 45: Interviews + Applications

What Interviewers Ask

- “Walk me through an incident”
- “How would you reduce false positives?”
- “Authentication vs authorization?”
- “Which logs do you check first?”

They test **thinking**, not memorization.

Apply Strategy

- Roles: SOC Analyst Intern, Security Analyst Intern, Blue Team roles
- Daily target:
  - 10 applications
  - 5 thoughtful LinkedIn messages

No begging. Show proof.

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Was this useful?

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